

POV: You Still Live With Your Parents at 30



— *While Everyone Else Pays Someone Else's Mortgage*

18

CHARACTERS

288

BEATS

11

STAGES

~25 min

RUNTIME

Interactive: tap any link to jump, tick the boxes, type notes. Use your PDF app's bookmarks panel to navigate.

Best in Adobe Acrobat Reader, Foxit, Xodo or a desktop browser so the boxes and notes save.

How to use this book

This book works in **two steps**. Every blue word is a link: tap it to jump. The dark bar at the top of every page has **Stage overview** and **Cast** buttons, and your PDF app's **bookmarks panel** lists every stage and character.

STEP 1 · Build your cast. Generate one reference image for each character using the [character prompts](#). Save the images and tick **Reference made**. Attach these references when generating beats so faces stay consistent.

STEP 2 · Generate the beats. Work stage by stage from the [stage overview](#). Each beat is one image on screen, about **5 seconds** of narration. Timecodes match the generated voiceover (voiceover/normal) exactly. Copy the image prompt, generate, and tick **Image**, **Animated** and **Placed** as you go. Use the notes box at the start of each stage for anything you want to remember.

In the edit: drop each image at its timecode, or import **beats_normal.srt** into CapCut or Premiere: each subtitle block is one beat, so you can line images up with it and get captions for free. Add a slow push-in or pan to every image.

Locked visual style

flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail.

Outfit and lighting by stage

STAGES	OUTFIT	LIGHTING
1 & 10 · Rooftop (age 30)	Black quarter-zip	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline
2-4 · Ages 22-24	Black hoodie, hood up, younger and thinner	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones
5-7 · Ages 25-27	Black crewneck sweater	soft clean daylight, neutral tones
8-9 · Ages 28-29	Black quarter-zip	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows
11 · Moving out	Black quarter-zip	warm natural light with amber accents
Bedroom at night	Any	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

Recurring visual motifs

31 glow-in-the-dark plastic stars on the bedroom ceiling · the spare key on a faded blue high-school lanyard · the \$800 envelopes · the circled “22 payments left” · the porch light · the heated rooftop pool · Theo and Jenna's red front door · Marcus's linen shirt and watch

STEP 1 OF 2

Build your cast

Generate these reference images before any beat.

18 characters

Tick each one when its reference is saved

CHARACTER	ROLE	APPEARS IN	
The Protagonist	Adult · ages 25–30 · main character	107 beats	☐ Reference made
The Protagonist (younger)	Age 22–24 · flashbacks and early years	36 beats	☐ Reference made
Marcus	Friend · flashy renter downtown	41 beats	☐ Reference made
Theo	Friend · homeowner with the red door	34 beats	☐ Reference made
Jenna	Friend · Theo's wife	31 beats	☐ Reference made
Priya	Friend · the one who notices	35 beats	☐ Reference made
Mother	His mother	26 beats	☐ Reference made
Father	His father	22 beats	☐ Reference made
Alana	The date	6 beats	☐ Reference made
Greg	His manager	6 beats	☐ Reference made
Aunt Denise	Thanksgiving relative	2 beats	☐ Reference made
Cousin Kyle	Thanksgiving relative	5 beats	☐ Reference made
The Uncle	Thanksgiving relative	1 beats	☐ Reference made
The Leasing Agent	Downtown loft	5 beats	☐ Reference made
The Mechanic	Repair shop	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The Loan Officer	The house purchase	4 beats	☐ Reference made
The Waiter	Rooftop party	2 beats	☐ Reference made
The Coworker	Market crash	2 beats	☐ Reference made

The Protagonist

ADULT · AGES 25–30 · MAIN CHARACTER



☐

Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet of the protagonist: a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan. Show him four times side by side, full body front view, same face and hair in every pose, deadpan expression: (1) black hoodie with the hood up, (2) black crewneck sweater, (3) black quarter-zip pullover, (4) dark tailored jacket over a black tee. Plain light-gray background, outfit labels under each pose. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head. He is always the darkest value in the frame.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 10, 13, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 110, 111, 112, 114, 115, 118, 119, 120, 122, 123, 124, 125, 126, 128, 129, 130, 134, 137, 138, 141 ... +67 more

The Protagonist (younger)

AGE 22-24 · FLASHBACKS
AND EARLY YEARS



☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The protagonist at age 22: a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, slightly thinner and more tired, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, worn jeans and old sneakers, holding a cardboard box. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

28, 30, 33, 36, 38, 39, 42, 43, 44, 48, 49, 51, 52, 59, 63, 64, 65, 70, 71, 72, 75, 76, 77, 80, 81, 89, 90, 91, 92, 95, 96, 97, 100, 104, 105, 108

Marcus

FRIEND · FLASHY RENTER
DOWNTOWN

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Marcus: a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut and a confident grin, wearing a cream linen shirt, slim chinos, loafers and a luxury wristwatch, holding a cocktail. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

2, 3, 6, 7, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 21, 22, 24, 25, 26, 50, 56, 60, 61, 63, 81, 87, 88, 121, 126, 142, 143, 153, 161, 162, 174, 186, 187, 188, 191, 193, 223, 224, 225, 226, 227 ... +1 more

Theo

FRIEND · HOMEOWNER
WITH THE RED DOOR

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Theo: a stocky bearded man in his late twenties with tired eyes and a friendly half-smile, wearing a flannel shirt, jeans and work boots. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

6, 8, 9, 12, 21, 22, 24, 25, 26, 50, 60, 61, 62, 63, 81, 82, 88, 126, 142, 143, 153, 174, 175, 177, 178, 179, 180, 181, 183, 184, 185, 193, 234, 251

Jenna

FRIEND · THEO'S WIFE

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Jenna: a warm woman in her late twenties with a long auburn ponytail and a kind smile, wearing a mustard cardigan over a white tee and jeans, house keys on a red ribbon in her hand. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

6, 8, 9, 12, 18, 19, 21, 22, 24, 25, 26, 50, 60, 61, 63, 81, 82, 85, 88, 126, 142, 143, 153, 174, 175, 177, 178, 179, 193, 234, 251

Priya

FRIEND · THE ONE WHO
NOTICES

☐ Reference made

CHARACTER PROMPT

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Priya: a calm, observant woman in her late twenties with dark wavy shoulder-length hair and small gold hoop earrings, wearing an olive jacket, black top and jeans, a thoughtful neutral expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

6, 10, 21, 22, 24, 25, 26, 50, 60, 61, 63, 81, 88, 124, 125, 126, 127, 128, 129, 130, 142, 143, 174, 193, 234, 237, 252, 254, 259, 260, 262, 264, 265, 266, 267

Mother

HIS MOTHER

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. His mother: a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair and reading glasses on a beaded chain, wearing a faded maroon cardigan over a floral blouse, a gentle protective expression. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

34, 38, 44, 45, 46, 97, 137, 138, 140, 145, 209, 210, 211, 212, 213, 214, 217, 218, 219, 248, 262, 263, 273, 278, 279, 280

Father

HIS FATHER

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. His father: a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a gruff but kind face, wearing a worn plaid shirt, khakis and reading glasses in his pocket. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

44, 51, 52, 53, 54, 55, 97, 132, 145, 146, 198, 200, 201, 204, 205, 248, 262, 273, 281, 282, 283, 284

Alana

THE DATE

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Alana: a lively woman in her mid-twenties with curly black hair and an expressive smile, wearing a rust-colored sweater and gold earrings. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

90, 91, 92, 93, 95, 96

Greg

HIS MANAGER

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Greg: a friendly balding middle-aged manager with a round face, wearing a tucked-in navy polo, khakis and a lanyard badge. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

103, 104, 105, 106, 107, 108

Aunt Denise

THANKSGIVING RELATIVE

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Aunt Denise: a heavysset woman in her sixties with teased hair and a sugary, nosy smile, wearing a bold red blouse and pearl necklace. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

65, 66

Cousin Kyle

THANKSGIVING RELATIVE

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. Cousin Kyle: a broad young man around twenty-four in a trucker cap and a team jersey, cocky grin, holding a car key fob. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)

67, 68, 69, 72, 176

The Uncle

THANKSGIVING RELATIVE

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. His uncle: a loud gray-haired man in his sixties wearing a sweater vest over a collared shirt, a booming laugh. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
70

The Leasing Agent

DOWNTOWN LOFT

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The leasing agent: a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer with a sleek bun, holding a tablet and a silver pen, a practiced sales smile. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
115, 116, 117, 119, 120

The Mechanic

REPAIR SHOP

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The mechanic: an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles, a short gray beard and a shop rag in his back pocket. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
166, 167

The Loan Officer

THE HOUSE PURCHASE

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The loan officer: a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie, neatly combed hair, holding a thick file folder. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
271, 272, 274, 275

The Waiter

ROOFTOP PARTY

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The waiter: a young man in a black apron and white shirt holding a payment tablet. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
14, 242

The Coworker

MARKET CRASH

☐ Reference made**CHARACTER PROMPT**

Character reference sheet, full body, front view and three-quarter view side by side, neutral standing pose, plain light-gray background, consistent proportions. The coworker: a nervous young man in a wrinkled dress shirt with a loosened tie and messy hair. Flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, semi-chibi proportions with an oversized head.

APPEARS IN BEATS (tap to jump)
102, 149

STEP 2 OF 2

Generate the beats

Tap a stage to jump straight to it.

288 beats · ~5s each
00:00 – 25:16

STAGE	TITLE	BEATS	TIME	
1	The Rooftop Age 30 · The secret in his pocket	1-27 27 beats	00:00-02:24	☐ Stage done
2	The Driveway and the Rule Age 22 · Four boxes and one decision	28-55 28 beats	02:24-05:04	☐ Stage done
3	"So When Are You Moving Out?" Age 22-23 · The question that never stops	56-79 24 beats	05:04-07:24	☐ Stage done
4	The Invisible Years Age 23-24 · Everyone else's life, in pictures	80-109 30 beats	07:24-10:02	☐ Stage done
5	The Loft and the Mortgage Age 25 · The pen, the envelope, the \$800	110-143 34 beats	10:02-12:59	☐ Stage done
6	The Crash Age 26 · When fear doesn't get a vote	144-173 30 beats	12:59-15:33	☐ Stage done
7	The Reversal Age 27 · Lives that have to be fed	174-194 21 beats	15:33-17:21	☐ Stage done
8	The Nine Seconds Age 28 · What the rent money really bought	195-214 20 beats	17:21-19:03	☐ Stage done
9	The Cost of Silence Age 29 · When the secret becomes a wall	215-240 26 beats	19:03-21:20	☐ Stage done
10	Back on the Rooftop Age 30 · Paid in full	241-268 28 beats	21:20-23:40	☐ Stage done
11	Moving Out After · The last star	269-288 20 beats	23:40-25:16	☐ Stage done

STAGE 1 OF 11

The Rooftop

Age 30 · The secret in his pocket

Beats 1–27 · 27 images
00:00 – 02:24

STAGE NOTES

001 BEAT 00:00 4.9s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	<i>“It’s 7:40 on a Saturday night and you’re standing on a rooftop downtown,”</i> CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe Protagonist IMAGE PROMPT Wide view of a downtown rooftop party at night, the protagonist standing near the railing holding a cocktail glass, guests mingling, string lights overhead, a glowing heated pool behind. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: stylish, quietly detached. CAMERAwide establishing shot, protagonist off-center left LIGHTINGwarm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOODstylish, quietly detached ACTIONholding his drink, observing the party
002 BEAT 00:04 7.2s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	<i>“holding a drink you didn’t pay for. It’s Marcus’s thirtieth birthday. His building. His roof.”</i> CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe ProtagonistMarcus IMAGE PROMPT The protagonist holding a fancy cocktail he didn’t buy, a “Happy 30th Marcus” gold balloon banner strung behind him, Marcus laughing with guests in the background. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: celebratory, ironic. CAMERAmedium shot LIGHTINGwarm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOODcelebratory, ironic ACTIONglancing at the banner

003

BEAT

00:12

6.0s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“His heated pool glowing blue behind everyone's heads. Your phone buzzes in your pocket.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

A sleek luxury apartment rooftop with a heated pool glowing turquoise, Marcus posing proudly beside it, guests' heads silhouetted against the blue glow. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: showy, affluent.

CAMERA

low-angle wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

showy, affluent

ACTION

Marcus spreading his arms proudly

004

BEAT

00:18

4.6s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You don't need to look. You already know what it says. One line.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's calm face in profile, eyes half-lidded, a faint glowing outline of a phone notification reflected in his glasses. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: tight close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: knowing, private.

CAMERA

tight close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

knowing, private

ACTION

not reaching for the phone

005

BEAT

00:22

7.2s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“A balance. Two words after it. Paid in full. You keep it in your pocket.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A ghostly overlay of a phone notification floating beside the protagonist reading "Paid in full", blurred so the details stay hidden. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up with overlay. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: mysterious.

CAMERA

close-up with overlay

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

mysterious

ACTION

the notification hovering faintly

006

BEAT

00:29

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“There are five of you up here. The same five since sophomore year.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Five friends standing together at the rooftop railing: the protagonist, Marcus, Theo, Jenna and Priya, the city skyline behind them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan; Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide group shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: familiar, nostalgic.

CAMERA

medium-wide group shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

familiar, nostalgic

ACTION

the friends clinking glasses

007

BEAT

00:34

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus in a linen shirt with the tags still on the inside collar.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Marcus

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus in a crisp linen shirt with a visible price tag still peeking out of the inside collar, holding a cocktail and grinning. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Marcus. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: flashy, careless.

CAMERA

medium close-up on Marcus

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

flashy, careless

ACTION

adjusting his collar without noticing the tag

008

BEAT

00:38

4.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Theo and Jenna holding hands, a little tired, a little proud,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna holding hands at the party, both looking tired but proud, house keys on a ribbon clipped to Jenna's bag. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: settled, weary pride.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

settled, weary pride

ACTION

leaning into each other

009

BEAT

00:42

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the way people look when they own a house. And Priya,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna standing together like a classic homeowner couple, a tiny thought bubble above them showing a small house with a red door. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: proud, slightly strained.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

proud, slightly strained

ACTION

smiling politely

010

BEAT

00:45

6.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“who notices everything and says almost none of it. Marcus taps a spoon against his glass.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya standing a little apart from the group, watching everyone quietly with a drink, her eyes landing on the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist soft in foreground. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: observant, quiet.

CAMERA

medium shot, protagonist soft in foreground

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

observant, quiet

ACTION

watching silently

011

BEAT

00:52

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He gives a speech about thirty. About building something. About how everyone up here made it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Marcus

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus giving a toast with one hand raised, speech-bubble icons of a house, a building and a trophy around him, guests cheering. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from the crowd. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: triumphant, showy.

CAMERA

medium shot from the crowd

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

triumphant, showy

ACTION

gesturing grandly

012

BEAT

00:58

6.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“He raises his drink toward Theo and Jenna's house, toward his own building, toward the city.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus raising his glass toward Theo and Jenna and then toward the luxury building behind him, the crowd's glasses lifting. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: celebratory, self-congratulatory.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	celebratory, self-congratulatory	sweeping his glass across the room

013

BEAT

01:04

4.4s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“When his glass swings past you, it slows down for half a second.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus's glass sweeping past the protagonist and slowing for a beat, Marcus's smile flickering awkwardly, the protagonist deadpan. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: awkward, subtle exclusion.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	awkward, subtle exclusion	the glass pausing near him

014

BEAT

01:08

5.9s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Then it keeps going. The waiter comes by with a tablet. Marcus waves him off.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus** **The Waiter**

IMAGE PROMPT

A young waiter in a black apron offering a payment tablet, Marcus waving him away with a flick of his hand. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; the waiter is a young man in a black apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: generous, showy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	generous, showy	Marcus waving off the bill

015

BEAT

01:14

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Tonight's on me, he says. Then he turns to you, grinning, warm, a little loud.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus turning toward the protagonist with a big, warm, loud grin, one arm around his shoulder. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: teasing, friendly.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	teasing, friendly	throwing an arm around him

016

BEAT

01:20

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you're still at your mom's, right? Still in the room with the stars on the ceiling?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A thought bubble above the group showing a childhood bedroom ceiling covered in glowing plastic stars, the protagonist below it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: embarrassing, nostalgic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with thought bubble	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	embarrassing, nostalgic	everyone imagining the bedroom

017

BEAT

01:25

7.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Everybody laughs. Not mean. Just familiar. You laugh too. Jenna touches your arm.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The friend group bursting into laughter, the protagonist laughing along with a flat, half-hearted smile. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide group shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: light teasing, hidden sting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide group shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	light teasing, hidden sting	everyone laughing

018

BEAT

01:32

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“If you ever need a place, she says, we have the spare room now.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Jenna touching the protagonist's arm kindly with a sympathetic expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: kind, pitying.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

kind, pitying

ACTION

Jenna resting her hand on his arm

019

BEAT

01:36

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Seriously. No rush. You say thanks. You mean it. You're thirty.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist nodding to Jenna with a small sincere look, his drink held low. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the protagonist. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: grateful, quiet.

CAMERA

close-up on the protagonist

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

grateful, quiet

ACTION

nodding thanks

020

BEAT

01:43

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You still sleep in the bedroom you slept in at nine. And sitting on that rooftop,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: the protagonist on the rooftop at thirty, and a small inset of the same bedroom with a twin bed and a nine-year-old version of him sleeping. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: ironic, intimate.

CAMERA

split-screen medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

ironic, intimate

ACTION

standing still at the railing

021 BEAT 01:48 5.8s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	<i>“you have more money than anyone holding a glass. Not more income. More money.”</i> CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe ProtagonistMarcusTheoJennaPriya IMAGE PROMPT The protagonist at the railing with faint gold numbers floating behind him like a ghostly bank balance, friends' glasses glinting beside him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secret wealth, quiet power. CAMERAmedium shot LIGHTINGwarm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOODsecret wealth, quiet power ACTIONgazing at the city
022 BEAT 01:54 7.3s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	<i>“The kind that stays. None of them know. Not Marcus. Not Theo. Not Jenna.”</i> CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe ProtagonistMarcusTheoJennaPriya IMAGE PROMPT The four friends laughing in a row, each with a small question-mark icon over their heads, the protagonist watching them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secret, ironic. CAMERAmedium-wide shot LIGHTINGwarm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOODsecret, ironic ACTIONfriends laughing unaware
023 BEAT 02:01 6.1s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	<i>“Not even Priya. Here's what nobody tells you about the years everyone pities you.”</i> CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe Protagonist IMAGE PROMPT The protagonist alone in a spotlight on a dark stage, a faint crowd of pitying faces around the edges. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide stylized shot. Lighting: dramatic single spotlight in darkness. Mood: introspective, revealing. CAMERAwide stylized shot LIGHTINGdramatic single spotlight in darkness MOODintrospective, revealing ACTIONstanding still in the spotlight

024

BEAT

02:07

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They don’t feel like a plan. They feel like an apology you keep making at every dinner.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

A montage of dinner tables with the protagonist apologizing with a raised hand at each one, friends' faces skeptical. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: three-panel montage. Lighting: warm dining light. Mood: weary, repetitive.

CAMERA

three-panel montage

LIGHTING

warm dining light

MOOD

weary, repetitive

ACTION

raising his hand apologetically

025

BEAT

02:13

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“This is how the friend everyone assumed was stuck turned out”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting slumped on a tiny stool labeled "STUCK" while the friends stand on taller pedestals. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide stylized shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: misjudged.

CAMERA

medium-wide stylized shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

misjudged

ACTION

sitting calmly on the stool

026

BEAT

02:17

3.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“to be the only one not paying for someone else's house.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

A row of houses with tiny strings attached to the friends' hands like puppets, and the protagonist standing free with no strings. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphorical shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: revealing, ironic.

CAMERA

wide metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

revealing, ironic

ACTION

the protagonist standing apart

027

BEAT

02:20

4.0s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“And why saying it out loud kept getting harder.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT

The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's mouth zipped with a small cartoon zipper, the party blurred behind him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secretive, heavy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	secretive, heavy	staying silent

STAGE 2 OF 11

The Driveway and the Rule

Age 22 · Four boxes and one decision

Beats 28-55 · 28 images
02:24 – 05:04

STAGE NOTES

028

BEAT

02:24

4.6s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Eight years earlier, you're twenty-two, standing in your parents' driveway”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger)

IMAGE PROMPT

A desaturated flashback of a suburban driveway, the younger protagonist standing beside an old sedan at age twenty-two. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot, desaturated. Lighting: flat cool overcast light, desaturated. Mood: tired beginnings.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot, desaturated	flat cool overcast light, desaturated	tired beginnings	standing in the driveway

029

BEAT

02:29

5.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“with everything you own in four cardboard boxes and a laundry basket.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Four cardboard boxes and a plastic laundry basket stacked on the driveway, labeled in marker "BOOKS", "CLOTHES", "KITCHEN", "MISC". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: sparse, humble.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool overcast light	sparse, humble	boxes sitting on the concrete

030

BEAT

02:34

5.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You have a degree. A job offer. \$41,000 a year.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger)

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist holding a diploma and an offer letter reading "Salary: \$41,000", the house behind him. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: modest achievement.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool overcast light	modest achievement	holding up the papers

031

BEAT

02:39

6.9s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You also have \$19,000 in student loans and \$2,500 in a checking account.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a laptop showing "Student Loans: \$19,000" and "Checking: \$2,500" on a cluttered desk. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: heavy, sobering.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

heavy, sobering

ACTION

the numbers glowing on screen

032

BEAT

02:46

5.9s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Your net worth sits around negative sixteen thousand. You tell everyone the same thing.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A simple bar chart on a phone screen dipping below zero with the label "Net worth: -\$16,500". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: bleak.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

bleak

ACTION

the bar sitting below the line

033

BEAT

02:52

4.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Just for a few months. Just until I get settled.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger)

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist on the phone in the driveway, holding up one finger, a speech bubble reading "Just a few months". The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: reassuring, unconvincing.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOOD

reassuring, unconvincing

ACTION

talking on the phone

034

BEAT

02:56

4.2s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Your mother has cleared out the closet. She's washed the old comforter.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

A modest childhood bedroom with an emptied closet and a freshly washed blue comforter folded on a twin bed, his mother smoothing it. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot of the bedroom. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: caring, nostalgic.

CAMERA

wide shot of the bedroom

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

caring, nostalgic

ACTION

his mother smoothing the comforter

035

BEAT

03:00

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She hasn't touched the ceiling. Thirty-one glow-in-the-dark stars, stuck up there when you were nine.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of thirty-one yellowed glow-in-the-dark plastic stars stuck to a white ceiling in a childish pattern. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: nostalgic, small.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

nostalgic, small

ACTION

the stars on the ceiling

036

BEAT

03:06

3.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They still light up faintly when you turn the lamp off.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The bedroom in darkness, the plastic stars glowing faintly green above the younger protagonist lying on the twin bed. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: quiet, nostalgic.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

quiet, nostalgic

ACTION

the lamp clicking off

037

BEAT

03:10

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The spare key is on the hook by the door. Same faded blue lanyard from high school.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A hallway by the front door with a wall hook holding a single brass key on a faded blue lanyard. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: homey, symbolic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

homey, symbolic

ACTION

the key hanging on the hook

038

BEAT

03:15

5.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother hands it to you like it's a formality. Like you never gave it back.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger) Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother handing the younger protagonist the key on the blue lanyard in the hallway, smiling softly. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: warm, matter-of-fact.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

warm, matter-of-fact

ACTION

placing the key in his hand

039

BEAT

03:20

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The first night, you lie under the stars and open a rental app.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger)

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist lying in bed under the glowing stars, his face lit by a phone showing a rental listing app. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from above. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: curious, wistful.

CAMERA

medium shot from above

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

curious, wistful

ACTION

scrolling the app

040

BEAT

03:25

9.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A one-bedroom across town. \$1,450 a month. Plus utilities. Plus parking. Call it \$1,700.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen showing an apartment listing "1BR Across Town \$1,450/mo" with small icons for utilities and parking. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: tempting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

tempting

ACTION

the listing on screen

041

BEAT

03:34

6.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“That's what being a grown-up costs in this city. That's the number everyone your age is paying.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone calculator showing "\$1,700" with a small grown-up figure in a suit icon beside it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: sobering.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars	sobering	the total glowing

042

BEAT

03:41

7.0s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“And then you make a decision so small it feels like nothing. You'll pay it anyway.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist lying still under the stars, a tiny lightbulb icon appearing faintly over his head. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: quiet decision.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars	quiet decision	his eyes narrowing in thought

043

BEAT

03:48

6.4s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Every month, \$1,700 leaves your paycheck, just like it would if you had your own place.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A split image: the younger protagonist paying into a jar labeled "RENT" in his childhood bedroom, and a stranger paying a landlord. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: parallel, deliberate.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen medium shot	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones	parallel, deliberate	dropping money into the jar

044

BEAT

03:54

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“\$500 goes to your parents. They try to refuse it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger) Mother Father

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist placing an envelope marked "\$500" on the kitchen table, his parents shaking their heads with hands raised. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavyset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium three-shot in a modest kitchen. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: warm, stubborn.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium three-shot in a modest kitchen	warm overhead kitchen light	warm, stubborn	his parents refusing

045

BEAT

03:59

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother pushes the first envelope back across the kitchen table. You push it back harder.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother pushing the envelope back across a worn kitchen table with two fingers. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the table. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: loving resistance.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on the table	warm overhead kitchen light	loving resistance	sliding the envelope back

046

BEAT

04:04

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She takes it the way people take something they plan to argue about later.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother slowly picking up the envelope with a skeptical, pursed-lip expression. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his mother. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: reluctant, unfinished.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on his mother	warm overhead kitchen light	reluctant, unfinished	lifting the envelope

047

BEAT

04:09

8.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The other \$1,200 disappears the morning the paycheck lands. Automatic. Gone before you can miss it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone notification at dawn reading "Auto-transfer: \$1,200 → Investment Account" on a nightstand beside a buzzing alarm clock. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: automatic, quiet.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

automatic, quiet

ACTION

the notification lighting up

048

BEAT

04:17

6.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“One rule. Made once. So you'd never have to decide again. You tell no one.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A single sticky note on the bedroom mirror reading "One rule.", the younger protagonist's reflection behind it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up through the mirror. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: simple, firm.

CAMERAmedium close-up
through the mirror**LIGHTING**flat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

simple, firm

ACTION

looking at the note

049

BEAT

04:24

5.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“There's no way to say it that doesn't sound like an excuse. I live with my parents,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist with an empty speech bubble struggling to fill it, crossed-out words scribbled inside. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: awkward, unexplainable.

CAMERA

medium close-up

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**awkward,
unexplainable**ACTION**

trying to find words

050

BEAT

04:29

6.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“but it's on purpose isn't a sentence anyone believes at twenty-two. The next morning,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a speech bubble reading "...on purpose" with friends' skeptical eye-rolls around it. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: dismissive.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

dismissive

ACTION

the bubble shrinking

051

BEAT

04:35

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your father is at the kitchen table with his coffee and the newspaper he still pays for.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

Morning kitchen, his father at the table with coffee, the younger protagonist in the background. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot of the kitchen. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: ordinary, quiet.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot of the kitchen

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

ordinary, quiet

ACTION

his father sipping coffee

052

BEAT

04:41

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He watches you pack a lunch in a reused takeout container. You sure about this?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist packing leftovers into a reused takeout container at the counter, his father watching over the newspaper. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: frugal, observed.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

frugal, observed

ACTION

snapping the lid shut

053

BEAT

04:46

5.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“he asks. Not the living here. The other thing. He saw the envelope.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Father**IMAGE PROMPT**

His father lowering the newspaper and asking a question with a raised eyebrow. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on his father. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: curious, protective.

CAMERA

medium close-up on his father

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

curious, protective

ACTION

lowering the paper

054

BEAT

04:51

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He doesn't know what the rest of the money is doing. He just knows you're doing something.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Father**IMAGE PROMPT**

His father squinting thoughtfully, a thought bubble with a question mark and a dollar sign. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his father. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: puzzled.

CAMERA

close-up on his father

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

puzzled

ACTION

thinking

055

BEAT

04:56

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say you're sure. You aren't. He nods and turns the page. He never asks again.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Father**IMAGE PROMPT**

His father going back to his newspaper, turning the page calmly. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: trusting, quiet.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

trusting, quiet

ACTION

turning the page

STAGE 3 OF 11

"So When Are You Moving Out?"

Age 22–23 · The question that never stops

Beats 56–79 · 24 images

05:04 – 07:24

STAGE NOTES

056

BEAT

05:04

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"That first summer, Marcus throws a party at his new apartment. Exposed brick."

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

A lively apartment party with exposed brick walls, Marcus hosting with a drink in hand. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: trendy, social.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

trendy, social

ACTION

Marcus welcoming guests

057

BEAT

05:10

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"A balcony. A dog-friendly building with no dog. Someone asks where everyone's living now,"

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A small balcony with string lights, and a framed "Pet Friendly" sign beside an empty dog bed. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: ironic, stylish.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

ironic, stylish

ACTION

guests stepping onto the balcony

058

BEAT

05:16

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"and the answers go around the circle like a toast. Downtown. Midtown."

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Speech bubbles going around the circle reading "Downtown", "Midtown", each friend raising a glass. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: proud, competitive.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

proud, competitive

ACTION

glasses raising

059

BEAT

05:22

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That place by the river. Then they get to you. You say,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A final bubble "By the river", then everyone turning to look at the younger protagonist. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: expectant.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

expectant

ACTION

heads turning

060

BEAT

05:26

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“I'm at my parents' for a bit. And a small silence opens up. Not cruel.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus Theo Jenna Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

The circle of friends frozen mid-sip with polite, uncomfortable smiles. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: awkward, careful.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

awkward, careful

ACTION

everyone going still

061

BEAT

05:32

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Just careful. The kind of silence people make around something they don't want to step on.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus Theo Jenna Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Friends tiptoeing carefully around the crack in the floor, avoiding eye contact. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: careful, avoidant.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

careful, avoidant

ACTION

tiptoeing

062

BEAT

05:38

7.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then Theo asks the question. Not unkindly. Just curious. So when are you moving out?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Theo****IMAGE PROMPT**

Theo leaning forward on the couch with a curious, friendly expression. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Theo. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: innocent curiosity.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium close-up on Theo	warm party lighting	innocent curiosity	asking the question

063

BEAT

05:46

8.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say soon. Everyone nods. The conversation rolls on. You'll hear that question for eight years.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna** **Priya****IMAGE PROMPT**

The younger protagonist answering, friends nodding and turning back to each other. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium group shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: brushed off.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium group shot	warm party lighting	brushed off	the conversation moving on

064

BEAT

05:54

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Thanksgiving that year, it gets asked by people who don't love you as gently.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)****IMAGE PROMPT**

Relatives at the table leaning toward the younger protagonist with nosy, judgmental expressions. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: judgmental.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm golden dining light	judgmental	relatives leaning in

065

BEAT

06:00

3.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"Your aunt Denise sets down a dish of sweet potatoes and asks,"

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Aunt Denise**

IMAGE PROMPT

Aunt Denise setting down a dish of sweet potatoes and turning to the younger protagonist with a fake sweet smile. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Aunt Denise is a heavyset woman in her sixties with teased hair and a bold red blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: nosy, sugary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden dining light	nosy, sugary	setting down the dish

066

BEAT

06:03

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"so where are you living now, honey? Before you can answer, your mother says,"

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Aunt Denise**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of Aunt Denise's raised eyebrows and a speech bubble with a small house icon and a question mark. Character notes: Aunt Denise is a heavyset woman in her sixties with teased hair and a bold red blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: prying.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	warm golden dining light	prying	asking

067

BEAT

06:08

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"he's home with us, and something in the room adjusts. Your cousin Kyle is twenty-four."

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Cousin Kyle**

IMAGE PROMPT

The relatives exchanging glances while Cousin Kyle sits up proudly across the table. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey; the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: shifting, judgmental.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm golden dining light	shifting, judgmental	glances traded

068

BEAT

06:14

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"He just bought a truck. \$640 a month for seventy-two months."

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Cousin Kyle**

IMAGE PROMPT

Cousin Kyle holding up a phone photo of a shiny new pickup truck with a "\$640/mo x 72" overlay. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: showy, financed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm golden dining light	showy, financed	showing the photo

069

BEAT

06:20

5.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He announces the payment like it's a trophy. Your uncle claps him on the back.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Cousin Kyle**

IMAGE PROMPT

Cousin Kyle beaming and holding a car key fob up like a trophy, relatives clapping. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey; the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: boastful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden dining light	boastful	raising the key fob

070

BEAT

06:25

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then he looks at you, and the hand doesn't come. He just says, well, no rush,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **The Uncle**

IMAGE PROMPT

His uncle turning toward the younger protagonist, his hand hovering and then dropping to his side. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his uncle is a loud gray-haired man in a sweater vest. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: withheld approval.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden dining light	withheld approval	the hand not coming

071

BEAT

06:29

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“buddy. Everybody's on their own timeline. It's kind. It's also a verdict. You pass the rolls.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist passing a basket of dinner rolls down the table, everyone else ignoring him. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: dismissed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden dining light	dismissed	passing the rolls

072

BEAT

06:36

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You notice nobody asks you a single follow-up question for the rest of the night.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Cousin Kyle**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist eating quietly at the end of the table while relatives chat animatedly with Kyle. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey; the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: ignored.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	warm golden dining light	ignored	eating silently

073

BEAT

06:42

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The first fourteen months, the \$1,200 doesn't build anything. It erases.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A bank app screen showing a "\$1,200" payment hitting a student loan, the loan bar shrinking. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: focused, erasing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones	focused, erasing	the bar shrinking

074

BEAT

06:48

10.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Loan statements shrink. \$19,000. Then \$13,000. Then \$6,400. You make the last payment”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Three loan statements side by side on a desk showing \$19,000, \$13,000 and \$6,400. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: steady progress.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones	steady progress	statements laid out

075

BEAT

06:58

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“from your car in a grocery store parking lot on a Tuesday. The screen says balance zero.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)****IMAGE PROMPT**

Phone screen reading "Loan Balance: \$0.00" with the younger protagonist's still face reflected above it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: quiet triumph.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOOD

quiet triumph

ACTION

the engine off

076

BEAT

07:04

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You sit there with the engine off. Nobody to tell. You drive home”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)****IMAGE PROMPT**

Phone screen reading "Loan Balance: \$0.00" with the younger protagonist's still face reflected above it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: quiet triumph.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOOD

quiet triumph

ACTION

the engine off

077

BEAT

07:09

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and eat leftovers at the same kitchen table you ate cereal at in fourth grade.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)****IMAGE PROMPT**

The younger protagonist eating leftovers alone at a worn kitchen table at night. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: humble, ordinary.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

humble, ordinary

ACTION

eating quietly

078

BEAT

07:14

5.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The next month, the \$1,200 finds a new home. An index fund.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen showing "Auto-transfer: \$1,200 → Index Fund" with a small seedling icon. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: new beginning.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

new beginning

ACTION

the transfer going through

079

BEAT

07:20

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The first deposit buys a few shares of something you'll never see.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Tiny share icons dropping into a dark, opaque box labeled "Index Fund". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: invisible growth.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

invisible growth

ACTION

shares dropping in

STAGE 4 OF 11

The Invisible Years

Age 23–24 · Everyone else's life, in pictures

Beats 80–109 · 30 images
07:24 – 10:02

STAGE NOTES

080 BEAT 07:24 3.3s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“Then come the years where it looks like you made a mistake.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe Protagonist (younger) IMAGE PROMPT The younger protagonist standing still on a busy sidewalk while everyone else walks quickly past him in a blur. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: soft neutral daylight. Mood: stuck, doubtful. CAMERA wide shot LIGHTING soft neutral daylight MOOD stuck, doubtful ACTION standing still
081 BEAT 07:28 5.2s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“Because everyone else's life starts happening on schedule. In public.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEATThe Protagonist (younger)MarcusTheoJennaPriya IMAGE PROMPT A group chat on a phone screen filling with photos of friends' new homes, cars and vacations, the younger protagonist's thumb scrolling. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: envious, public. CAMERA close-up insert LIGHTING flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones MOOD envious, public ACTION scrolling the feed

082

BEAT

07:33

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“With pictures. Theo and Jenna buy a house at twenty-five.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna standing proudly in front of a small house with a "SOLD" sign in the yard. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: proud, milestone.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight

MOOD

proud, milestone

ACTION

holding up the sign

083

BEAT

07:37

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A small one with a red door and a backyard that floods when it rains.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A backyard with a large muddy puddle spreading across the grass in the rain. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool rainy light. Mood: foreshadowing.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool rainy light

MOOD

foreshadowing

ACTION

rain pooling in the yard

084

BEAT

07:42

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The group chat fills with paint swatches. Then a puppy.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A phone group chat filled with paint swatch photos and then a photo of a fluffy puppy. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: cheerful, domestic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

cheerful, domestic

ACTION

new photos popping in

085

BEAT

07:46

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then a photo of keys in Jenna's hand, a ribbon tied around them.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up photo on a phone of a house key in Jenna's hand tied with a red ribbon. Character notes: Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: celebratory.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

celebratory

ACTION

the key photo appearing

086

BEAT

07:50

6.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Someone writes, adults. Thirty hearts follow. Marcus moves again. A higher floor.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A group chat message reading "adults" followed by a cascade of thirty heart reactions. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: validating, social.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

validating, social

ACTION

hearts piling up

087

BEAT

07:57

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A gym in the basement. A doorman who learns his name. His rent climbs to \$2,100.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

A uniformed doorman greeting Marcus by name in a marble lobby, a rent notice in Marcus's hand reading "\$2,100". Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; the doorman is an older man in a burgundy uniform and cap. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: status, expensive.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

status, expensive

ACTION

the doorman tipping his hat

088

BEAT

08:04

6.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He mentions it the way people mention the price of a watch. Your updates get smaller.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus casually showing off a luxury wristwatch while mentioning his rent, friends nodding. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: braggy.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

braggy

ACTION

tapping his watch

089

BEAT

08:10

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then they stop. What are you going to post? A photo of your mother's meatloaf?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist's phone showing his own social profile with an empty feed and a blinking cursor. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: invisible.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

invisible

ACTION

the cursor blinking

090

BEAT

08:16

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The ceiling? You go on a date. Her name is Alana.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Alana**

IMAGE PROMPT

A casual restaurant date, the younger protagonist seated across from Alana at a small table with candles. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: hopeful.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

hopeful

ACTION

both smiling over menus

091

BEAT

08:20

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She’s funny and quick, and she likes the same terrible movie you do.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Alana**

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana laughing at a joke, the younger protagonist almost smiling, a movie poster on the restaurant wall. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: easy chemistry.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

easy chemistry

ACTION

laughing together

092

BEAT

08:25

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Halfway through dinner she asks where you live. You tell her the truth.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Alana**

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana leaning in with a curious question, the younger protagonist answering honestly. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: honest, risky.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

honest, risky

ACTION

talking over dinner

093

BEAT

08:29

6.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She says, oh. Just that. Oh. Her face doesn't change much. It just closes, gently,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Alana**IMAGE PROMPT**

Alana's polite smile freezing, a tiny speech bubble reading "Oh.". Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Alana. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: cooling.

CAMERA

close-up on Alana

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

cooling

ACTION

her smile stiffening

094

BEAT

08:36

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“like a door being shut so it won't wake anyone. When the check comes,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)**IMAGE PROMPT**

A visual metaphor of a door being gently closed in a dark hallway. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim hallway light. Mood: soft finality.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim hallway light

MOOD

soft finality

ACTION

the door clicking shut

095

BEAT

08:41

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“she reaches for her half before you can reach for all of it. Not rude.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist (younger) Alana**IMAGE PROMPT**

Alana quickly sliding her card into the check folder before the younger protagonist can reach for it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on hands. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: efficient, distant.

CAMERA

close-up on hands

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

efficient, distant

ACTION

her card going in first

096

BEAT

08:46

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Efficient. You're being placed in a category, and the category doesn't get a second date.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Alana**

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana waving a polite goodbye on the sidewalk while walking away, the younger protagonist standing alone. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: final, lonely.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	cool night streetlight	final, lonely	Alana walking away

097

BEAT

08:52

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You drive home and park in the same spot in the driveway.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Mother** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist's old sedan pulling into his parents' driveway at night, parking in the same spot. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavysset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool night light. Mood: routine, quiet.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	cool night light	routine, quiet	the car pulling in

098

BEAT

08:55

6.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your father's left the porch light on. He always does. The rule runs the entire time.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A warm porch light glowing above the front door of the modest family house at night. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: welcoming, steady.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm porch light against cool night	welcoming, steady	the porch light shining

099

BEAT

09:02

11.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Every raise, half disappears into the account. \$1,200 becomes \$1,400. Then \$1,650. You never feel richer.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Three monthly transfer amounts stacking on screen: "\$1,200", "\$1,400", "\$1,650". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: growing quietly.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

growing quietly

ACTION

the numbers rising

100

BEAT

09:13

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You change a number in an app and go back to work. At work,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)**

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist at an office desk changing a number in a banking app, then turning back to his monitor. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: routine, unremarkable.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOOD

routine, unremarkable

ACTION

tapping and returning to work

101

BEAT

09:17

6.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the team goes to lunch on Fridays. Everyone talks about rent the way people talk about weather.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers chatting animatedly about rent with weather-style icons (sun, clouds, rain) floating above them. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: everyday, comparative.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

everyday, comparative

ACTION

coworkers talking

102

BEAT

09:24

9.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Somebody's landlord raised it \$150. Somebody else found a place with in-unit laundry for only \$1,900.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Coworker****IMAGE PROMPT**

Another coworker excitedly showing an apartment listing "In-unit laundry \$1,900". Character notes: the coworker is a nervous young man in a wrinkled dress shirt and loosened tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: excited.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	excited	holding up the listing

103

BEAT

09:33

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your manager, Greg, a nice man with three kids and a boat he never uses,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Greg****IMAGE PROMPT**

A small thought bubble above Greg showing three kids and an unused boat under a tarp. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: wholesome, suburban.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with thought bubble	soft clean daylight	wholesome, suburban	Greg chuckling

104

BEAT

09:38

3.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“turns to you. And where are you these days?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Greg****IMAGE PROMPT**

Greg turning toward the younger protagonist with a friendly question. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: curious.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	curious	leaning toward him

105

BEAT

09:41

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say you're at home for now. He nods slowly. At your review,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Greg**

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg nodding slowly with a sympathetic look while the younger protagonist answers. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: polite pity.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	polite pity	nodding

106

BEAT

09:45

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“he gives you the biggest raise on the team. He says it's for your work.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Greg**

IMAGE PROMPT

A performance review meeting in a glass office, Greg handing over a document reading "Raise: Top of team". Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: rewarding.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	rewarding	handing the paper

107

BEAT

09:50

4.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then he adds, quietly, maybe this helps you get your own place.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Greg**

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg leaning in and speaking quietly with a hopeful expression, a thought bubble showing a little apartment. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: kind, assuming.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	kind, assuming	leaning in

108

BEAT

09:54

3.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He means well. He thinks he's paying for your escape.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist (younger)** **Greg**

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg patting the younger protagonist's shoulder with a warm, hopeful smile. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain black hoodie with the hood up, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: well-meaning.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	well-meaning	the shoulder pat

109

BEAT

09:58

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He doesn't know half of it will be in the account by Monday.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen on Monday morning showing half the raise transferring to "Investment Account".

Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: quiet, secret.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones

MOOD

quiet, secret

ACTION

the transfer completing

STAGE 5 OF 11

The Loft and the Mortgage

Age 25 · The pen, the envelope, the \$800

Beats 110-143 · 34 images
10:02 - 12:59

STAGE NOTES

110

BEAT

10:02

4.9s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Two things happen in those years that you won’t understand until later.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on his childhood bed looking up at the plastic stars, two small question-mark icons above him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: foreshadowing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars	foreshadowing	looking up

111

BEAT

10:07

6.1s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“The first is an apartment. You’re twenty-five and you’re tired of explaining yourself.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking alone down a downtown sidewalk with a tired, worn-out expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium tracking-style shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: weary.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium tracking-style shot	soft clean daylight	weary	walking toward the building

112

BEAT

10:13

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“So you go look at a loft downtown. Brick walls. Tall windows.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A sunlit downtown loft with exposed brick walls and tall factory windows, the protagonist standing in the middle. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point-perspective shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: aspirational.

CAMERA

wide
one-point-perspective
shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

aspirational

ACTION

looking around

113

BEAT

10:18

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A kitchen with a gas stove and a little shelf for spices you don't own.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

An empty wooden spice shelf on the loft kitchen wall beside a sign reading "\$1,650/mo". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempting, hollow.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

tempting, hollow

ACTION

the empty shelf

114

BEAT

10:23

6.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“\$1,650 a month. You can afford it. That's the problem. It isn't reckless.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a paycheck stub next to the "\$1,650" listing, both balanced on a scale. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: conflicted.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

conflicted

ACTION

weighing the papers

115

BEAT

10:29

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It's just more. The leasing agent is about your age.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Protagonist](#) [The Leasing Agent](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

A leasing office with a glass desk, the leasing agent smiling across from the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: professional, persuasive.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOODprofessional,
persuasive**ACTION**

the agent greeting him

116

BEAT

10:34

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She's wearing a blazer and she's very good at her job.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Leasing Agent](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

The leasing agent confidently presenting a glossy brochure. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on the leasing agent. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: polished, persuasive.

CAMERAmedium shot on the
leasing agent**LIGHTING**

soft clean daylight

MOODpolished,
persuasive**ACTION**

presenting the brochure

117

BEAT

10:38

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She slides the lease across a glass desk and sets a pen on top of it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Leasing Agent](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

The leasing agent sliding a lease contract across a glass desk. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the desk. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: decisive.

CAMERA

close-up on the desk

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

decisive

ACTION

the lease sliding forward

118

BEAT

10:42

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Everything about the room says, you belong here. You pick up the pen.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Protagonist](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist picking up the pen in the stylish office, motivational wall art reading "Welcome Home" behind him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempted.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

tempted

ACTION

lifting the pen

119

BEAT

10:47

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you stand there long enough that she starts to smile less. You put the pen down.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **The Leasing Agent**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist frozen with the pen hovering over the signature line, the leasing agent's smile slowly fading. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tense, hesitant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	tense, hesitant	hovering the pen

120

BEAT

10:53

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say you need to think. She says the unit won't last. You say you understand.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **The Leasing Agent**

IMAGE PROMPT

The leasing agent warning with a raised finger while the protagonist nods calmly and stands to leave. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: pressure resisted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	pressure resisted	standing up

121

BEAT

10:59

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That night the group chat lights up. Marcus on his balcony. City behind him.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

A phone screen at night showing a group chat photo of Marcus posing on his balcony. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: envious.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars	envious	the photo appearing

122

BEAT

11:04

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A caption with three fire emojis. And you lie under thirty-one plastic stars,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lying on his childhood bed staring up at thirty-one glowing plastic stars. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: lonely, reflective.

CAMERA

high-angle shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

lonely, reflective

ACTION

lying still

123

BEAT

11:10

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“wondering if you're building something or just getting very good at hiding from your own life.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist curled under the blanket while faint shadows of a life passing by move across the ceiling. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: avoidant, uncertain.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

avoidant, uncertain

ACTION

pulling the blanket up

124

BEAT

11:16

6.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You don't feel disciplined. You feel behind. Priya is the only one who ever gets close.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya standing in a doorway looking toward the protagonist with a gentle, perceptive expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: observant, caring.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

observant, caring

ACTION

watching quietly

125

BEAT

11:23

3.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“At a bar that year, she watches you order water with lime”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

A busy bar, the protagonist ordering water with lime from a bartender, Priya beside him noticing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket; the bartender is a tattooed young woman in a black tee. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: frugal, noticed.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

frugal, noticed

ACTION

holding the water glass

126

BEAT

11:26

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“while everyone else orders the second round. She doesn't make a joke about it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Friends ordering a second round of colorful cocktails while the protagonist sips water. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

contrast

ACTION

glasses being refilled

127

BEAT

11:31

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just slides her fries toward the middle of the table, where you can reach them.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya sliding a basket of fries toward the center of the table. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the table. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: quiet kindness.

CAMERA

close-up on the table

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

quiet kindness

ACTION

sliding the fries

128

BEAT

11:36

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Later, in the parking lot, she asks if you're okay for money. Not pity.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

A dark parking lot outside the bar, Priya asking a quiet question beside the protagonist's car. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: concerned.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	cool night streetlight	concerned	leaning against the car

129

BEAT

11:41

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Just a question. You tell her you're fine. She looks at your car,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist replying with a small shrug, Priya listening without judgment. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: honest concern.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	cool night streetlight	honest concern	shrugging

130

BEAT

11:45

3.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“then at you, and says, okay. She doesn't believe you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya glancing at the protagonist's old dented sedan and then back at him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: skeptical, kind.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	cool night streetlight	skeptical, kind	looking at the car

131

BEAT

11:49

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just decides not to push. You'll think about that parking lot for years.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

The empty parking lot under a single streetlight after everyone has left. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: memorable, quiet.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool night streetlight

MOODmemorable,
quiet**ACTION**

the lot sitting empty

132

BEAT

11:54

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The second thing, you almost miss. Your father's hours get cut. Not fired.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His father in a worn work jacket staring at a work schedule with hours crossed out. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool light. Mood: worried pride.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool light

MOOD

worried pride

ACTION

staring at the schedule

133

BEAT

12:00

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Just cut. Thirty hours a week instead of forty. Your parents don't tell you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A weekly schedule sheet with forty hours crossed out and "30 HRS" written in red. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool light. Mood: financial strain.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool light

MOOD

financial strain

ACTION

the red marks

134

BEAT

12:06

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You find out from the envelope on the counter with the bank's logo,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

An envelope with a bank logo lying on a kitchen counter, the protagonist picking it up. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: discovery.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

discovery

ACTION

lifting the envelope

135

BEAT

12:10

9.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“opened and refolded too many times. The mortgage. \$1,180 a month. Eleven years left. You don't ask.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A mortgage statement creased from being folded many times, showing "\$1,180/month". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: heavy.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm overhead kitchen light	heavy	the creases visible

136

BEAT

12:20

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You just change one number. Starting that month, \$800 goes to your parents instead of \$500.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A banking app screen changing a transfer from "\$500" to "\$800" labeled "Parents". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: generous, silent.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight, neutral tones	generous, silent	the number changing

137

BEAT

12:28

3.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You tell your mother it's because you eat more than you used to.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist handing his mother a thicker envelope, smiling awkwardly, a plate of food in his other hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: playful excuse.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm overhead kitchen light	playful excuse	handing the envelope

138

BEAT

12:31

4.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She looks at you a long time. She doesn't argue.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother looking at the protagonist for a long silent moment, her eyes softening. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his mother. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: understanding.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on his mother	warm overhead kitchen light	understanding	accepting the envelope

139

BEAT

12:35

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You don't know it yet, but that \$800 isn't going to groceries.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A grocery bag sitting empty on the counter while the "\$800" envelope slides past it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: redirected.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm overhead kitchen light	redirected	the envelope bypassing the groceries

140

BEAT

12:40

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother is sending every dollar of it straight to the principal on the house.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother at the kitchen table at night filling out a mortgage payment slip with the "\$800" envelope beside it. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: secret devotion.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	dim warm lamp light	secret devotion	writing on the slip

141

BEAT

12:45

4.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And for almost four years, the plan doesn't make you feel smart.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at his desk looking at a calendar with four years crossed out, his expression flat. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: unsatisfied.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	unsatisfied	staring at the calendar

STAGE 6 OF 11

The Crash

Age 26 · When fear doesn't get a vote

Beats 144-173 · 30 images

12:59 – 15:33

STAGE NOTES

144

BEAT

12:59

5.4s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You're twenty-six when the market falls apart. Not a dip. A real one.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A red market crash graph plunging on a TV screen in a family living room. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool TV glow in a dim living room. Mood: alarming.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool TV glow in a dim living room

MOOD

alarming

ACTION

the line falling

145

BEAT

13:05

3.6s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“The kind that leads the evening news in your parents' living room”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His parents' living room with the evening news showing a "MARKET CRASH" headline. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavyset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool TV glow in a dim living room. Mood: anxious.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool TV glow in a dim living room

MOOD

anxious

ACTION

the news playing

146

BEAT

13:08

4.3s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“while your father shakes his head at the screen. Over four bad months,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His father in an armchair shaking his head at the television while the protagonist watches from the doorway. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: cool TV glow in a dim living room. Mood: grim.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

cool TV glow in a dim living room

MOOD

grim

ACTION

shaking his head

147

BEAT

13:13

6.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your account loses twenty-two percent. At work, people say, did you see what the market did?”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers gathered around a monitor with shocked faces looking at falling stock charts. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: panicked.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	panicked	pointing at the screen

148

BEAT

13:19

3.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“in the voice you'd use for a car accident.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers speaking in hushed, grim tones as if discussing a car accident. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: grave.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	grave	whispering

149

BEAT

13:22

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A guy two desks over sells everything on a Thursday afternoon and goes home early.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Coworker**

IMAGE PROMPT

The same coworker grabbing his coat and leaving early, a calendar showing Thursday. Character notes: the coworker is a nervous young man in a wrinkled dress shirt and loosened tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: defeated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	defeated	walking out

150

BEAT

13:28

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He tells you he's done gambling. You nod. You open the app at work”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a phone screen showing a balance dropping from "\$31,000" to "\$24,000". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: painful, stark.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight, neutral tones	painful, stark	the number falling

151

BEAT

13:32

9.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and watch \$31,000 turn into \$24,000. That year, you put in more than \$19,000.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a phone screen showing a balance dropping from "\$31,000" to "\$24,000". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: painful, stark.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

painful, stark

ACTION

the number falling

152

BEAT

13:41

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And in December the balance is lower than it was in January.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A balance chart comparing December lower than January with a red arrow pointing down. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: frustrating.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

frustrating

ACTION

the chart ending lower

153

BEAT

13:46

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Theo's house is still standing. Marcus's view is still there. Their choices didn't evaporate.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna**

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna's red-door house standing firm, and Marcus's skyline view through a window. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: stable for others.

CAMERA

split-screen wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

stable for others

ACTION

both scenes calm

154

BEAT

13:52

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Yours look like they did. You want to stop. You don't.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's finger hovering over a "STOP TRANSFERS" button on his phone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over his hand. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempted.

CAMERA

close-up over his hand

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

tempted

ACTION

hovering

155

BEAT

13:57

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Not because you're brave. Because the transfer was set up years ago,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

An old automatic transfer setting dated years ago on a dusty screen. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: automated discipline.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

automated discipline

ACTION

the setting locked in

156

BEAT

14:01

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“back before fear had a vote. It keeps buying while everything is on sale.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A store window with a giant "SALE" banner and small share icons being bought up in a cart. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: opportunity.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

opportunity

ACTION

shares going into the cart

157

BEAT

14:06

3.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You just can't feel that yet. It only feels like losing.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring at his phone with a downcast expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: discouraged.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

discouraged

ACTION

staring blankly

158

BEAT

14:10

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That night you lie under the ceiling and count the stars. Thirty-one. Same as always.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in bed counting the glowing plastic stars on the ceiling with a slow finger. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: steady, lonely.

CAMERA

high-angle shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

steady, lonely

ACTION

pointing at each star

159

BEAT

14:16

5.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They're the only thing in your life that hasn't moved. Somewhere in that stretch,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the unchanged ceiling stars in the same pattern, glowing softly. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: constant.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

constant

ACTION

the stars glowing

160

BEAT

14:22

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus gets drinks with you and looks at the blue lanyard hanging out of your jacket pocket.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the faded blue lanyard dangling out of the protagonist's jacket pocket. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: nostalgic, noticed.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

nostalgic, noticed

ACTION

the lanyard hanging out

161

BEAT

14:27

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You still carry that thing? he says. It's from high school.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus pointing and laughing at the lanyard. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Marcus. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: teasing.

CAMERA

medium close-up on Marcus

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

teasing

ACTION

laughing

162

BEAT

14:31

4.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Let me buy you a key ring at least. You tell him it's lucky.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus holding up a sleek leather key ring offer. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: flashy, condescending.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

flashy, condescending

ACTION

offering the key ring

163

BEAT

14:35

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He lets it go. Then your car's transmission dies on the highway.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's car stalled on a highway shoulder with hazard lights blinking and smoke rising. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool overcast daylight. Mood: stressful.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool overcast daylight

MOOD

stressful

ACTION

smoke rising from the hood

164

BEAT

14:40

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“\$2,300. The kind of bill that would have flattened you at twenty-two.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A repair estimate reading "Transmission: \$2,300" held in the protagonist's hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool overcast daylight. Mood: daunting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool overcast daylight

MOOD

daunting

ACTION

holding the estimate

165

BEAT

14:45

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You pay it from your checking account standing at the counter of the repair shop. The mechanic,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A gritty auto repair shop counter with tools on the wall, the protagonist paying calmly. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm shop lighting. Mood: steady.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm shop lighting

MOOD

steady

ACTION

standing at the counter

166

BEAT

14:51

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“an older man with grease in the creases of his knuckles, waits for you to flinch.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Mechanic](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

An older mechanic with grease-stained knuckles behind the counter, watching closely. Character notes: the mechanic is an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on the mechanic. Lighting: warm shop lighting. Mood: curious.

CAMERA

medium shot on the mechanic

LIGHTING

warm shop lighting

MOOD

curious

ACTION

wiping his hands

167

BEAT

14:56

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Most people do. You don't. He looks at you a second longer than usual.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Protagonist](#) [The Mechanic](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

The mechanic raising an eyebrow, impressed, as the protagonist pockets his card. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the mechanic is an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the mechanic. Lighting: warm shop lighting. Mood: respectful.

CAMERA

close-up on the mechanic

LIGHTING

warm shop lighting

MOOD

respectful

ACTION

raising an eyebrow

168

BEAT

15:02

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You're three steps into the parking lot before you realize you weren't afraid.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT [The Protagonist](#)

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking across the repair shop parking lot, pausing mid-step with a dawning realization. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: surprised calm.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

surprised calm

ACTION

stopping mid-step

169

BEAT

15:06

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The fear just wasn't there. Somewhere in the boring years,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing relaxed with no sweat drops or worry lines, a broken chain lying at his feet. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: freed.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical
shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

freed

ACTION

standing still

170

BEAT

15:10

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“without a date you could circle, it left. By twenty-seven, the market turns.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A pale ghost of fear drifting away from the protagonist over a montage of ordinary workdays. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: quiet transformation.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical
shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

quiet
transformation

ACTION

the ghost fading

171

BEAT

15:16

3.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The shares you bought in the fire start doing what shares do.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

Tiny share icons sprouting into small green plants inside a glass box. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: growth.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

growth

ACTION

plants sprouting

172

BEAT

15:19

6.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The account doesn't just recover. It passes everything it was before. \$80,000.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

An investment balance on a phone reading "\$80,000" with a green recovery graph. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: rewarding.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

rewarding

ACTION

the number climbing

173

BEAT

15:26

7.9s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Then \$100,000 on an ordinary Wednesday. You notice it the way you'd notice the weather.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist glancing at his phone and then looking out a window at the weather with the same flat expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: nonchalant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	nonchalant	glancing outside

STAGE 7 OF 11

The Reversal

Age 27 · Lives that have to be fed

Beats 174-194 · 21 images
15:33 – 17:21

STAGE NOTES

174

BEAT

15:33

6.4s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“And around that time, the reversal starts. Quiet. Invisible. Real.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus Theo Jenna Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

A seesaw slowly tipping in the protagonist's favor while friends' side sinks. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: turning point.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium metaphorical shot	soft clean daylight	turning point	the seesaw tipping

175

BEAT

15:40

6.3s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Theo and Jenna's interest rate resets. Their payment jumps \$640 a month.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna at their kitchen table staring at a letter reading "New payment: +\$640/mo". Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: stressed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	stressed	holding the letter

176

BEAT

15:46

4.8s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“The same number as Kyle's truck. You notice it. You don't say it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Cousin Kyle

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: the "+\$640" mortgage letter beside Cousin Kyle's "\$640/mo" truck photo. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: ironic parallel.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen close-up	soft clean daylight, neutral tones	ironic parallel	both numbers matching

177

BEAT

15:51

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then the basement floods, the one that always flooded, and this time it's \$9,000.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna's basement flooding, water rising over boxes and a washing machine. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool dim basement light. Mood: disaster.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool dim basement light

MOOD

disaster

ACTION

water rising

178

BEAT

15:57

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Jenna mentions it at dinner like it's a joke. Theo doesn't laugh.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Jenna laughing nervously at a dinner table while Theo stares down at his plate, unsmiling. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm dining light. Mood: strained.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm dining light

MOOD

strained

ACTION

Jenna forcing a laugh

179

BEAT

16:02

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They've been paying for five years and the bank still owns most of the red door.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

The red front door of Theo and Jenna's house with a large bank logo shadow cast over most of it. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: ironic ownership.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

ironic ownership

ACTION

the shadow covering the door

180

BEAT

16:07

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“At their Fourth of July barbecue, Theo stands at the grill a little too long”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo standing alone at the grill with a spatula, staring blankly at the smoke. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Theo. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: preoccupied.

CAMERA

medium shot on Theo

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

preoccupied

ACTION

staring at the grill

181

BEAT

16:12

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“after the burgers are done. He tells you they refinanced.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Theo

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo confiding in the protagonist beside the grill, finished burgers piled on a plate. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: confessional.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

confessional

ACTION

Theo lowering his voice

182

BEAT

16:16

3.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Stretched it back out to thirty years to make the payment work.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of refinance paperwork reading "Term: 30 years" on a patio table. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: resigned.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

resigned

ACTION

the paper flapping in the breeze

183

BEAT

16:20

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“We'll own it when we're sixty-two, he says, and flips a burger that doesn't need flipping.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo forcing a grin with a thought bubble showing an old man with a cane standing by the red door. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: wry, sad.

CAMERA

medium shot with thought bubble

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

wry, sad

ACTION

grinning

184

BEAT

16:25

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He laughs. You laugh. Neither of you means it. Behind him,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Theo

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and the protagonist both going quiet, their smiles fading. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: heavy, unspoken.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

heavy, unspoken

ACTION

staring at the grill

185

BEAT

16:30

7.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the backyard is still soft from the last flood. Marcus's rent goes to \$2,900.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo

IMAGE PROMPT

The soggy, muddy backyard behind Theo with lawn chairs sinking into the soft ground. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: lingering damage.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

lingering
damage

ACTION

chairs sinking slightly

186

BEAT

16:37

3.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He gets a letter slid under his door about the renewal.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Marcus

IMAGE PROMPT

An envelope slid under a sleek apartment door, Marcus picking it up. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: uneasy.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

uneasy

ACTION

bending to pick it up

187

BEAT

16:40

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He shows it to you on his phone and says, it's fine, it's fine,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Marcus

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus showing the protagonist the notice on his phone at a café table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: forced calm.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

forced calm

ACTION

holding out the phone

188

BEAT

16:44

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the way people say it when it isn't. Four years in that building.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Marcus

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus waving it off with an uneasy grin, a small sweat drop on his forehead. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Marcus. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: denial.

CAMERA

close-up on Marcus

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

denial

ACTION

waving his hand

189

BEAT

16:49

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You do the math in your head without meaning to. More than \$110,000 in rent.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring into the distance with small mental math figures floating around his head. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: calculating.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

calculating

ACTION

doing math silently

190

BEAT

16:55

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Every dollar of it paying down a stranger's mortgage. He owns the linen shirts.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Rent checks flowing into a stranger landlord's mortgage chute. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA

metaphorical wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

ironic

ACTION

money flowing away

191

BEAT

17:00

3.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He owns the watch. He doesn't own a single brick.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

A brick wall with a "NOT YOURS" sign hanging on it beside Marcus. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: hollow.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

hollow

ACTION

Marcus leaning on the wall

192

BEAT

17:04

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And the landlord he's never met just bought a second building. Nobody failed.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A smiling landlord in a suit shaking hands over a "SOLD" sign on a second apartment building. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: ironic success.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

ironic success

ACTION

shaking hands

193 BEAT 17:10 4.4s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“That's the part that matters. They just built lives that have to be fed.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Marcus Theo Jenna Priya IMAGE PROMPT Houses, cars and apartments drawn as hungry creatures with open mouths beside the friends. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: draining. CAMERA metaphorical medium shot LIGHTING soft clean daylight MOOD draining ACTION the creatures waiting to be fed
194 BEAT 17:15 6.0s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“And the feeding never stops. Yours, quietly, started feeding you.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot) IMAGE PROMPT Bills feeding endlessly into a hungry slot machine. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: endless. CAMERA close-up metaphor LIGHTING soft clean daylight, neutral tones MOOD endless ACTION bills flowing in

STAGE 8 OF 11

The Nine Seconds

Age 28 · What the rent money really bought

Beats 195–214 · 20 images
17:21 – 19:03

STAGE NOTES

195 BEAT 17:21 3.7s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“You’re twenty-eight when you read a line on a statement twice.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist IMAGE PROMPT The protagonist reading a paper statement twice at the kitchen table, eyebrows slightly raised. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: surprised. CAMERA medium shot LIGHTING soft warm daylight, gentle shadows MOOD surprised ACTION reading closely
196 BEAT 17:24 6.0s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“Before a single new deposit, your account grew \$14,000 that year on its own.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot) IMAGE PROMPT A statement line reading "Growth this year: +\$14,000" glowing on the page. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: passive reward. CAMERA close-up insert LIGHTING soft warm daylight, gentle shadows MOOD passive reward ACTION the number glowing
197 BEAT 17:31 3.4s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“While you worked. While you slept under the stars.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot) IMAGE PROMPT A statement line reading "Growth this year: +\$14,000" glowing on the page. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: passive reward. CAMERA close-up insert LIGHTING soft warm daylight, gentle shadows MOOD passive reward ACTION the number glowing

198

BEAT

17:34

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“While you sat at the kitchen table listening to your father complain about the neighbor's leaf blower.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His father complaining while pointing out the window at a neighbor with a loud leaf blower. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: humorous, domestic.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

humorous,
domestic

ACTION

pointing outside

199

BEAT

17:40

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your salary is still the bigger number. But it isn't the only one working anymore.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)**

IMAGE PROMPT

A second income stream drawn as a flowing river joining the main river. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: compounding.

CAMERA

metaphorical wide shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

compounding

ACTION

the rivers merging

200

BEAT

17:45

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That same winter, your father slips on the back steps carrying groceries.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His father slipping on icy back steps while carrying grocery bags, groceries flying. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cold winter daylight. Mood: sudden, painful.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cold winter daylight

MOOD

sudden, painful

ACTION

falling backward

201

BEAT

17:50

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A broken hip. Surgery. Eight weeks of recovery. Your mother can't lift him alone.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

A hospital bed with his father in a hip brace, a surgery schedule on the wall. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: cool hospital light. Mood: serious.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

cool hospital light

MOOD

serious

ACTION

lying in bed

202

BEAT

17:57

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you're there. Not because you rearranged your life. Because you never left it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist appearing at the bottom of the stairs, ready to help. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: present, dependable.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

present,
dependable

ACTION

stepping forward

203

BEAT

18:02

5.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You hear him fall from upstairs. You're at the bottom of the steps in nine seconds.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist rushing down the stairs, a stopwatch overlay reading "0:09". The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium tracking-style shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: urgent.

CAMERA

medium tracking-style
shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

urgent

ACTION

running down the stairs

204

BEAT

18:07

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You drive him to the hospital in your repaired car. Every morning for eight weeks,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist driving the repaired sedan with his father in the passenger seat wincing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot inside the car. Lighting: cold winter daylight. Mood: urgent, caring.

CAMERA

medium two-shot inside
the car

LIGHTING

cold winter daylight

MOOD

urgent, caring

ACTION

gripping the wheel

205

BEAT

18:12

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“you help him from the bed to the chair before work. Every night, you help him back.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist helping his father from a bed into an armchair in the early morning. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: caring, steady.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

caring, steady

ACTION

lifting under his arm

206

BEAT

18:18

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The money you didn't spend on rent bought something you didn't know you were buying.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a gift box labeled "PRESENCE" instead of keys to a loft. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: unexpected value.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

unexpected value

ACTION

holding the gift

207

BEAT

18:23

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Being in the house when it mattered. That's the first time the whole strange arrangement feels”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the window of his childhood bedroom, a soft smile almost appearing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: quiet realization.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

quiet realization

ACTION

looking outside

208

BEAT

18:28

6.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“like it was worth it. Not the balance. The nine seconds. One night during his recovery,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A scale with a bank balance on one side and a stopwatch reading "0:09" on the other, the stopwatch side heavier. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: meaningful.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

meaningful

ACTION

the stopwatch side tipping down

209

BEAT

18:35

5.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your mother sits across from you at the kitchen table with a pencil and the mortgage statement.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother sitting down across from the protagonist at the kitchen table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: intimate.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

intimate

ACTION

sitting down

210

BEAT

18:41

3.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She doesn't hide it this time. She slides it over. Look,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother laying a pencil and the mortgage statement openly on the table. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: open, trusting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

open, trusting

ACTION

placing them down

211

BEAT

18:44

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“she says. And she taps a number she's circled. Twenty-two payments left.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of his mother's finger tapping a circled number reading "22 payments left". Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: emotional, proud.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

emotional, proud

ACTION

tapping the circle

212

BEAT

18:50

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It was supposed to be eight more years. She doesn't say thank you. She doesn't have to.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother looking down at the statement, eyes glistening, saying nothing. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his mother. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: grateful, unspoken.

CAMERA

close-up on his mother

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

grateful,
unspoken

ACTION

eyes lowered

213

BEAT

18:55

4.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just keeps her finger on the number a little longer than she needs to,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother's finger resting firmly on the circled number. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: tender.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

tender

ACTION

finger pressing down

214

BEAT

18:59

3.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“like it might move if she lets go.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother's finger guarding the number as if holding it in place. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: fragile hope.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

fragile hope

ACTION

not letting go

STAGE 9 OF 11

The Cost of Silence

Age 29 · When the secret becomes a wall

Beats 215–240 · 26 images
19:03 – 21:20

STAGE NOTES

215

BEAT

19:03

5.7s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“But something else starts happening too. Something you don't like. Your mother's friends”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT

The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist frowning slightly as a gray storm cloud forms faintly above the house. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: unease.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	unease	frowning

216

BEAT

19:08

5.1s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“from church ask her about you. You can hear her through the kitchen wall one Sunday.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT

The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the hallway with his ear near the kitchen wall, listening. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: eavesdropping.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	eavesdropping	listening

217

BEAT

19:13

4.9s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“He's figuring it out, she says. He's a late bloomer. He'll be fine.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT

Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother on the phone in the kitchen, smiling bravely while speaking. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: defensive, loving.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm overhead kitchen light	defensive, loving	talking on the phone

218

BEAT

19:18

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Her voice is the one she uses to defend things. And she's defending you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother****IMAGE PROMPT**

Close-up of his mother's determined face mid-sentence. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: tight close-up. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: protective.

CAMERA

tight close-up

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

protective

ACTION

speaking firmly

219

BEAT

19:23

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Because she doesn't know about the account. Nobody does. You could walk in and end it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Mother****IMAGE PROMPT**

His mother standing like a shield in front of a small silhouette of the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: loyal, unaware.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

loyal, unaware

ACTION

holding up a shield

220

BEAT

19:29

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“One sentence. You stand in the hallway with your hand on the wall.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist****IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist standing frozen in the hallway, one hand pressed flat against the wall. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: torn.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

torn

ACTION

standing still

221

BEAT

19:34

4.0s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Then you go back upstairs. You never chose to lie.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking back up the stairs to his bedroom. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: retreating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	retreating	climbing the stairs

222

BEAT

19:38

5.8s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You just never corrected anyone. And at some point those became the same thing.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Two road signs reading "LYING" and "SILENCE" merging into a single sign. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: uncomfortable truth.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphorical close-up	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	uncomfortable truth	the signs merging

223

BEAT

19:44

6.6s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“Then it gets uglier. Marcus calls one night. He's moving out. Somewhere cheaper.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on a phone call in his bedroom, Marcus shown in a split panel packing boxes in his apartment. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shots. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: humbling.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split-screen medium shots	dim evening light	humbling	Marcus taping a box

224

BEAT

19:50

3.8s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“He's embarrassed about it, so he makes it about you. Hey, he says,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus**

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus pacing in his half-packed apartment with an embarrassed grin. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Marcus. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: embarrassed.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot on Marcus	dim evening light	embarrassed	pacing

225

BEAT

19:54

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“why don't we get a two-bedroom together? I can cover the deposit.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus****IMAGE PROMPT**

Marcus on the phone gesturing enthusiastically, a thought bubble showing a two-bedroom apartment. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: eager.

CAMERA

medium shot with
thought bubble

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

eager

ACTION

gesturing

226

BEAT

19:59

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It'd be good for you. Get you out of there. He's being generous. He's being kind.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus****IMAGE PROMPT**

Marcus with a warm, kind smile on the phone. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Marcus. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: sincere.

CAMERA

close-up on Marcus

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

sincere

ACTION

smiling

227

BEAT

20:05

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And he's offering to rescue you with money he doesn't have. You could tell him the truth.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Marcus****IMAGE PROMPT**

Marcus offering a life ring made of crumpled bills, a hole in the ring. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium
shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

ironic

ACTION

tossing the ring

228

BEAT

20:11

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You could pay the whole year's rent on a two-bedroom without blinking.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist****IMAGE PROMPT**

A thought bubble above the protagonist showing him casually paying a full year's rent. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: hidden capability.

CAMERA

medium shot with
thought bubble

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

hidden capability

ACTION

imagining paying

229

BEAT

20:16

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Instead you say, let me think about it. And you let him feel generous.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the phone with a neutral expression, saying he'll think about it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: evasive.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

evasive

ACTION

speaking calmly

230

BEAT

20:20

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And when you hang up, you notice you're smiling. That's the part that scares you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lowering the phone, a small unsettling smile on his face. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: disturbing self-awareness.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOODdisturbing
self-awareness**ACTION**

smiling faintly

231

BEAT

20:26

6.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You've started to enjoy it. Being underestimated. The private math at every table.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist catching his own smiling reflection in a dark window and freezing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: unsettling.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

unsettling

ACTION

staring at his reflection

232

BEAT

20:32

6.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Knowing what nobody knows. You catch yourself guarding the secret, not because you need to anymore,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist****IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist guarding a small locked chest at the foot of his bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: possessive.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

possessive

ACTION

resting a hand on the chest

233

BEAT

20:38

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“but because you like who you get to be inside it. And it lands on you,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist****IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist sitting inside a small glowing secret room, comfortable and alone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: seductive isolation.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

seductive isolation

ACTION

sitting comfortably

234

BEAT

20:43

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“lying under the stars. If you need everyone to think you're stuck,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Marcus** **Theo** **Jenna** **Priya****IMAGE PROMPT**

Marionette strings attached to the protagonist from above, held by shadowy friends' hands. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: controlled.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

controlled

ACTION

strings tugging

235

BEAT

20:47

4.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“their opinion is still running your life. You just flipped the direction.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

The marionette strings flipping upside down while still attached. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

ironic

ACTION

strings reversing

236

BEAT

20:52

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“For years, you refused to perform success. And somewhere along the way,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist rejecting a flashy costume labeled "SUCCESS" on a rack. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: principled.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

principled

ACTION

pushing it away

237

BEAT

20:56

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“you started performing failure just as hard. Priya texts you the next morning. Out of nowhere.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's phone lighting up with a text from Priya on his nightstand at sunrise. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: caring.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

caring

ACTION

the phone lighting up

238

BEAT

21:03

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You okay? You've seemed far away lately. You start typing the truth. The rule.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist typing a long reply on his phone in bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over his hand. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: vulnerable.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up over his hand	cool early-morning light	vulnerable	typing quickly

239

BEAT

21:10

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The number. Eight years of it. You look at it for a long time.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring at the long unsent message on his screen. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: hesitant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	cool early-morning light	hesitant	staring

240

BEAT

21:15

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then you delete it and send a photo of your mother's meatloaf.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist deleting the message and sending a photo of meatloaf instead. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: deflecting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	cool early-morning light	deflecting	tapping send

STAGE 10 OF 11

Back on the Rooftop

Age 30 · Paid in full

Beats 241-268 · 28 images
21:20 – 23:40

STAGE NOTES

241 BEAT 21:20 5.8s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“Which brings you back to the rooftop. Marcus's thirtieth. The heated pool.” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist IMAGE PROMPT The protagonist back on the rooftop at night, standing at the railing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: return to present. CAMERA medium shot LIGHTING warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOOD return to present ACTION standing at the railing
242 BEAT 21:25 4.5s ☐ Image ☐ Animated ☐ Placed	“The tablet the waiter never got to hand you. Your phone in your pocket,” CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Waiter IMAGE PROMPT The waiter walking away with the unused payment tablet. Character notes: the waiter is a young man in a black apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: unseen. CAMERA medium shot LIGHTING warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline MOOD unseen ACTION the waiter walking off

243

BEAT

21:30

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“heavy with one line you haven't shown anyone. Here's what it says.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist**IMAGE PROMPT**

Close-up of the protagonist's hand resting over his jacket pocket with a faintly glowing phone outline. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: heavy secret.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

heavy secret

ACTION

his hand resting

244

BEAT

21:35

7.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A loan servicing notice. Your parents' mortgage. Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)**IMAGE PROMPT**

Phone screen reading "Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00. PAID IN FULL" with a green check mark. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: triumphant.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

triumphant

ACTION

the check mark glowing

245

BEAT

21:42

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Paid in full. Eight years of \$800 envelopes on the kitchen table.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)**IMAGE PROMPT**

Phone screen reading "Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00. PAID IN FULL" with a green check mark. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: triumphant.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

triumphant

ACTION

the check mark glowing

246

BEAT

21:49

4.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Every one of them sent to the principal. Eleven years of payments finished in eight.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

Envelopes flying into a mortgage document labeled "Principal". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: purposeful.

CAMERA

metaphorical close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

purposeful

ACTION

envelopes landing

247

BEAT

21:54

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The house you've been laughed at for living in doesn't belong to the bank anymore.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

The modest family house at dusk with laughter speech bubbles floating around it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm dusk light. Mood: vindicated.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm dusk light

MOOD

vindicated

ACTION

the house standing

248

BEAT

21:59

4.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It belongs to the two people who left the porch light on.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother and father on the porch under the warm porch light, smiling softly. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan; his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool dusk. Mood: deserved peace.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool dusk

MOOD

deserved peace

ACTION

sitting together

249

BEAT

22:03

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You've been paying a mortgage this whole time. Just not someone else's.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the rooftop railing with a calm, quiet smile. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: vindicated.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

vindicated

ACTION

looking out at the city

250

BEAT

22:08

4.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The party thins out after midnight. Theo and Jenna leave first,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

The rooftop party thinning out after midnight, empty glasses on tables. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: winding down.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

winding down

ACTION

guests leaving

251

BEAT

22:12

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“because their dog has been alone since six. Marcus disappears into a group of coworkers.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Theo Jenna

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna waving goodbye as they head for the elevator. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: tired, warm.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

tired, warm

ACTION

waving

252

BEAT

22:18

2.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And then it's just you and Priya at the railing,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist and Priya standing alone at the rooftop railing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: intimate.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

intimate

ACTION

leaning on the railing

253

BEAT

22:21

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the city spread out below like a circuit board. She doesn't look at you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

The city below glowing like a circuit board of lights. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: vast, quiet.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

vast, quiet

ACTION

the lights glittering

254

BEAT

22:26

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just says it. So when are you actually moving out? The same question.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of Priya's speech bubble reading "So when are you actually moving out?". Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: recurring question.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

recurring question

ACTION

the bubble appearing

255

BEAT

22:32

6.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Eight years later. On a different roof. For eight years, this is where you've said soon.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

A stack of speech bubbles reading "soon" piled up beside the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: habitual.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

habitual

ACTION

the bubbles stacked

256

BEAT

22:39

5.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“This time you take out your phone. You open the account. Not the mortgage.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist**IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist taking out his phone and opening an investment app. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: decisive.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

decisive

ACTION

opening the app

257

BEAT

22:44

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The other one. And you set it face up on the railing between you.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist**IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist placing his phone face up on the rooftop railing between them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the railing. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: vulnerable.

CAMERA

close-up on the railing

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

vulnerable

ACTION

setting the phone down

258

BEAT

22:49

7.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“\$214,000. Priya looks at it for a long time. She doesn't say wow.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)**IMAGE PROMPT**

Phone screen showing "\$214,000" in large digits on the rooftop railing. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: stunning reveal.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

stunning reveal

ACTION

the number glowing

259

BEAT

22:56

3.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She doesn't ask how. She just goes quiet, the way you do”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya going quiet and still, absorbing it. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: reflective.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	reflective	standing still

260

BEAT

22:59

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“when a story you thought you knew turns out to be a different story.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist and Priya silhouetted at the railing against the glittering city. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: reframing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	reframing	silent together

261

BEAT

23:04

6.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“How long? she finally asks. Since the driveway, you say. Since the four boxes.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded flashback inset of the driveway and four cardboard boxes beside the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with flashback overlay. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: origin.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with flashback overlay	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	origin	remembering

262

BEAT

23:10

4.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She asks if your parents know. You tell her about the mortgage.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT The Protagonist Priya Mother Father

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya asking about his parents while the protagonist shows the mortgage notice. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket; his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavysset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: deepening.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	deepening	showing the notice

263

BEAT

23:14

3.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“About the envelopes. About your mother's finger on the number.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Mother

IMAGE PROMPT

A montage of the envelopes and his mother's finger on the circled number. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: two-panel montage. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: emotional.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
two-panel montage	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	emotional	the memories appearing

264

BEAT

23:18

4.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Priya turns back to the city and doesn't say anything for a while.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT Priya

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya turning back toward the city, quiet, the night wind lifting her hair. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: moved.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	moved	looking out

265

BEAT

23:23

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then she says, that's the most grown-up thing anyone on this roof has done.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya looking at the protagonist with deep respect. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: admiring.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	admiring	speaking softly

266

BEAT

23:28

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She laughs once, softly, not at you. We all thought you were stuck,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya laughing softly with warmth, not mockery. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: tender.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	tender	laughing

267

BEAT

23:32

4.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“she says. And you give her the only true thing you have left.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Priya**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking at Priya with a vulnerable, open expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: honest.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	honest	meeting her eyes

268

BEAT

23:36

3.6s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“For a while, you say. I was.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT

The Protagonist

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist answering with a faint, real smile at the railing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: humble truth.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	humble truth	speaking quietly

STAGE 11 OF 11

Moving Out

After · The last star

Beats 269–288 · 20 images

23:40 – 25:16

STAGE NOTES

269

BEAT

23:40

4.0s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

*“Three weeks later, you sign for a small house on the east side.”***CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT** No characters (environment or insert shot)**IMAGE PROMPT**

A cozy brick two-family house on a tree-lined street with a "SOLD" sign. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: accomplished.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

accomplished

ACTION

the sign in the yard

270

BEAT

23:44

5.2s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

*“A two-family. You'll live in one half. The other half pays for itself.”***CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT** The Protagonist**IMAGE PROMPT**

Split view of the two-family house, the protagonist on one side and a tenant family moving in on the other. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: cutaway medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: smart, stable.

CAMERA

cutaway medium shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

smart, stable

ACTION

both halves lived in

271

BEAT

23:49

4.4s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

*“You put down forty percent. The loan officer reads your file twice,”***CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT** The Protagonist The Loan Officer**IMAGE PROMPT**

A loan office with a middle-aged loan officer reading a thick file across a desk from the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: professional.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

professional

ACTION

reading the file

272

BEAT

23:53

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“then looks up at you with a different face than the one he walked in with.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Loan Officer**

IMAGE PROMPT

The loan officer's expression shifting to respect, eyebrows raised. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the loan officer. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: newfound respect.

CAMERA

close-up on the loan officer

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

newfound respect

ACTION

adjusting his tie

273

BEAT

23:58

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He'd seen the address on your application. Your parents' address. He'd assumed.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the loan application with the parents' home address highlighted. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavysset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: assumption.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

assumption

ACTION

the address highlighted

274

BEAT

24:04

4.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Now he asks if you'd like coffee. He walks you to the elevator himself.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **The Loan Officer**

IMAGE PROMPT

The loan officer offering the protagonist a cup of coffee with a broad smile. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: deferential.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

deferential

ACTION

holding out the coffee

275

BEAT

24:08

5.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He tells you to call his cell, not the office line. Your last night at home,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Loan Officer**

IMAGE PROMPT

The loan officer handing over a business card with a handwritten cell number. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: exclusive.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

exclusive

ACTION

handing the card

276

BEAT

24:13

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“you stand on your old bed and peel the stars off the ceiling. One by one.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A handful of peeled stars in his palm, one remaining stuck on the ceiling. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: tender.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

tender

ACTION

the last star clinging

277

BEAT

24:19

6.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Thirty of them come off clean. One won't let go. You leave it there. Downstairs,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A handful of peeled stars in his palm, one remaining stuck on the ceiling. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: tender.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

tender

ACTION

the last star clinging

278

BEAT

24:25

5.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your mother is at the kitchen table, holding the spare key on the faded blue lanyard.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother holding the spare key on the faded blue lanyard in her hands. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: nostalgic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

nostalgic

ACTION

holding the key

279

BEAT

24:31

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She tries to give it back to you. You close her hand around it.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother holding the key out toward the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: letting go.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

letting go

ACTION

offering the key

280

BEAT

24:35

3.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Keep it, you tell her. I’ll need it. On the porch,”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Mother**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist smiling softly at his mother across the kitchen table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: loving.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	dim warm lamp light	loving	speaking gently

281

BEAT

24:39

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your father is sitting in the chair he couldn’t get out of on his own a year ago.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded inset of his father struggling to stand during his hip recovery. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
split medium shot	warm porch light against cool night	contrast	struggling to rise

282

BEAT

24:44

5.5s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He stands up without help. He shakes your hand like you’re someone he just met and likes.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist** **Father**

IMAGE PROMPT

His father shaking the protagonist’s hand warmly on the porch. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: respect.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	warm porch light against cool night	respect	shaking hands

283

BEAT

24:50

6.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then the porch light comes on behind him. Same as every night. Nobody touched the switch.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father****IMAGE PROMPT**

The porch light clicking on above his father's head. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: constant.

CAMERA

low-angle medium shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool night

MOOD

constant

ACTION

the light coming on

284

BEAT

24:56

4.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It's on a timer now. He set it the week you moved home.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **Father****IMAGE PROMPT**

A faded flashback inset of his father installing the timer eight years ago. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with flashback overlay. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: loving.

CAMERAmedium shot with
flashback overlay**LIGHTING**

warm porch light against cool night

MOOD

loving

ACTIONhis father screwing in the
timer**285**

BEAT

25:00

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It started with a number on a rental app. \$1,700 a month.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **No characters (environment or insert shot)****IMAGE PROMPT**

A phone rental app screen showing “\$1,700/mo” fading into the night sky. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: origin.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGwarm natural light with amber
accents**MOOD**

origin

ACTION

the number fading

286

BEAT

25:05

2.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The money changed what you were free to choose.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist****IMAGE PROMPT**

The protagonist walking toward his new two-family house with a box under his arm. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm dusk light. Mood: freedom.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm dusk light

MOOD

freedom

ACTION

walking up the path

287

BEAT

25:08

2.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The silence changed what you were willing to say.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT **The Protagonist**

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing quietly on the new porch, mouth closed, keys in hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized head, messy curly jet-black hair, thick black rectangular glasses, heavy half-lidded tired eyes with faint dark under-eye lines, thick slightly furrowed black eyebrows, pale off-white skin and a small flat frowning mouth, always deadpan, wearing a black quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm dusk light. Mood: reserved.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm dusk light

MOOD

reserved

ACTION

standing still

288

BEAT

25:11

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And the house you were laughed at for living in was never someone else's.”

CHARACTERS IN THIS BEAT No characters (environment or insert shot)

IMAGE PROMPT

A final close-up of the single plastic star still glowing on the empty bedroom ceiling. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: final, tender.

CAMERA

extreme close-up

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with
the faint green glow of plastic
ceiling stars

MOOD

final, tender

ACTION

the star glowing